Basket of skills

MADRAS

These are gift-boxes and containers made from Nature's own gifts, flexible bamboo and pliable palm fibre interwoven and plaited in a variety of forms and sizes to fulfil a gamut of needs, from gifting sarees to storing perishables. Square, round, octagonal, cylindrical — the shapes are innumerable and stretch from the huge and auspicious Chettinad baskets for storing grains and pulses to the tiny ones to hold sweets for children. Banana fibre containers for bringing borosil dishes piping hot to the table and brooms made of palm stem fibre give an inkling of the applications of the craft of "Basketry" at the exhibition organised by Crafts Council of India and Crafts Council of Kerala at the former's premises (6, Kasturi Estates), above Contemporary Arts and Crafts (from March 9 to 14).

Some of the products are the result of the interaction and training of Crafts Council of Kerala with a few groups in Kochi, Kollam and Thiruvananthapuram . Bamboo sisal and palm fibre have been exploited to the full in fashioning the various home accessories.

"The accent is on packaging as an income generation scheme" says Ms. Geeta Ram of the Crafts Council of India. "The inherent skill and motifs have been retained but some of the designs are original and the aim is to create jobs in small underprivileged communities and to promote new concepts for an ancient craft to assist quick marketability."

Kerala with its swaying palms and abundant foliage offers an ideal basket of raw materials for the craft. Mrs. Reena Varughis Secretary of the Kerala Crafts Council, says that hundreds of women employed in basketry units in Kerala are benefited and the palm stem fibre table mats are so popular that demand invariably exceeds supply. The products on display which include innovations in coconut shell, are the combined output of four societies in Kerala.

Kerala, however, is not the only State to figure in the exhibition. Basketry and mats from West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Haryana and Delhi are also on view. Some of the new designs are still rough prototypes in rudimentary stages and are to be perfected upon in a workshop to be held soon for the craftsmen explains Ms. Geeta Mehra of the Crafts Council

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